



A

Socialist

Manifesto

for real change

Victorian
Socialists





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“We need people in parliament who will stand up to the billionaires and big corporate interests that dominate politics—people who will fight for the working class and the least well off. That’s what socialists are all about.”

Jordan van den Lamb
Victorian Socialists candidate
for Melbourne

Victorian
Socialists



A socialist manifesto for real change

The November Victorian state election will be one of the most consequential political moments in recent Australian history. The Labor government—which has given us greater inequality and driven public services to breaking point after twelve years in power—is facing a serious challenge not only from the Liberal-National Coalition, but also from the far-right One Nation party.

Polls indicate that One Nation is likely to get a big vote. It could hold the balance of power or even enter a coalition government with the Liberals, opening a path to further gains in the NSW state election in March and the federal election due by mid-2028. In the face of this challenge, Labor politicians say that everyone who opposes One Nation should give the ALP another four years. They want us to rally around the status quo of declining living standards, unaffordable housing, a decrepit public education system and hospitals that are at breaking point. That, they say, is the only alternative to the attacks a Liberal-One Nation coalition would bring.

But it's clear from other countries that this kind of “lesser evil” politics—when governments appeal to voters on the basis of being less bad than the alternative—often helps the far right. From the US to Britain and beyond: attempts by capitalism's centre-left and centre-right parties to double down on politics as usual (frequently combined with the adoption of aspects of the far right's own agenda) have led to more misery for far-right parties to capitalise on and a greater normalisation of far-right politics.

The antidote to the reactionary, bigoted and anti-worker politics of One Nation isn't more of the same from a Victorian Labor government that has failed working-class people and the oppressed. We need a political alternative that understands who is actually responsible for the many problems in society. It's not Muslims, migrants, single mothers and trans people, as One Nation would have us believe. It's the billionaires, major property investors and developers, big banks and other major corporations that have grown rich at workers' expense. And it's the major party politicians who serve them—or who, like One Nation, are desperate to serve them.

Victorian Socialists is the alternative. In November, we are putting forward a vision of hope, solidarity and working-class unity. Our vision is an economy and a society run by, and for, the working class. And we're taking this message and vision to Victorian voters on a bigger scale than anything attempted by socialists in modern Australian history. We intend to run candidates in all 88 of Victoria's lower house districts, as well as in each of the eight upper house regions. This year, every Victorian will have the chance to vote for a socialist alternative to the rotten, crisis-ridden status quo of capitalism, and to the toxic far-right politics of One Nation.

Whatever happens, the performance of One Nation will be big news on election night. We hope we can play a role in limiting their gains. But more importantly, we hope that there's also a surge in the socialist vote that's impossible to ignore. If we can achieve that—making clear that there's an increasing number of voters embracing anti-capitalist politics—it will provide a boost to our movement across Australia and further establish socialism as a growing force in Australian political life.

This manifesto first provides an overview of Victoria's politics, economy and society. Then it outlines our socialist vision and the key policies we'll be putting forward in this election. We hope you will be inspired to join us and get active in the party, and convince others to do the same.



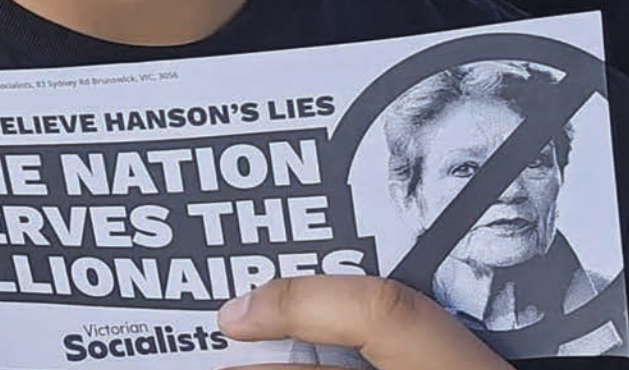


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DON'T BELIEVE HANSON'S LIES

**ONE NATION
SERVES THE
BILLIONAIRES**

FROM **Victorian
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**ONE NATION
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**VICTORIAN
SOCIALIST**

Our economy and politics are rigged in the interests of the super-rich

Australia's economy works only for those at the top. Year after year, the billionaire class increase their wealth, and the banks, supermarkets and other big corporations increase their profits. Meanwhile, more and more people struggle just to get by.

The *Australian Financial Review's* 2026 Rich List shows that the collective wealth of Australia's billionaires increased by \$25.7 billion in the past year—that's \$50,000 per minute! The twenty richest Australians today hold more wealth than the poorest 3 million households (that's around 7.5 million people).

Every year, whether it's Labor or the Coalition in power, this already obscene level of inequality grows. There's a class war going on. But it's being waged almost exclusively by the super-rich and their political servants against the rest of us. And the longer it goes on, the more it's killing off the hope for a better future for working-class people.

Billionaires like Gina Rinehart and Anthony Pratt (Victoria's richest person), both big supporters of Donald Trump, are among this country's biggest whingers—endlessly complaining about the prospect of marginally higher tax rates on their obscene wealth. But our economy and political system are thoroughly rigged in their favour. How else could they have gotten so rich in the first place if it wasn't?

Every extra billion dollars taken by those at the top is a billion dollars that's been taken from the working-class and our communities. The richer they become, the more our side suffers: from wages that fall behind inflation, crumbling infrastructure, inadequate social services and the ongoing, deepening crisis in our public schools and health system.

The entire fortunes of Rinehart and Co. were built from theft: the historic theft of Indigenous land, theft of the natural resources that should be used to the benefit of all, and theft of the value produced by the workers they employ and exploit. And it's our political class—whether from Labor, the Liberals or One Nation—that supports and helps them get away with it.

Put politicians on a worker's wage

Politicians are overpaid and out of touch. The starting salary of a Victorian MP is more than \$219,000. That puts them in the richest 4 percent of Australia's income earners. The government calls this a "basic salary"—because it's their minimum wage. There are tens of thousands of dollars more up for grabs after being elected. Ministers get more than \$390,000, putting them in the richest 1 percent of

the population. The result is that parliament attracts careerists and grifters more interested in making life better for themselves and other elites than making life better for working-class people and our communities.

As the main parties of government, Labor and the Coalition are the worst offenders. The politicians in those parties view the obscene

Parliament is stacked with people who are happy with the way things are, and who identify more with the wealthy capitalist elites and their paid lobbyists than they do with the people they're supposed to represent. Politicians think nothing of spending tens of thousands in taxpayer funds on travel, accommodation and other things that the vast majority of workers can only dream of charging to the "company card". They are regularly wined and dined by big business owners and lobbyists, who they magically get jobs with after they leave office. Politicians know that if they serve big business, they will be rewarded when the voters finally kick them out or they retire from politics.

Victorian Socialists want to turn the tables on the billionaires and their loyal political servants. We're sick of living in a society where a parasitic minority enriches itself at the cost of working-class people and the environment. We're sick of our basic human needs—food, housing, education and health—coming a distant second to capitalist profits. We're going to fight like hell, in this election and beyond, to take the power back and build an economy and society that works for the many, not just the few.

salaries and entitlements as god-given rights. They have become integrated into an elite class of capitalists whose salaries and wealth grow to greater heights of obscenity every year. And they think it only fitting that they should enjoy the same kind of lifestyle and privileges as their big business mates.

One Nation doesn't yet have the same kind of influence. But we can already see how easily they will fall into the same pattern. Party leader Pauline Hanson takes home a salary of more than \$340,000—so she's been close to the top 1 percent for a decade. Despite "earning" such a huge amount, she hasn't even bothered to show up to a

large portion of Senate votes. One investigation found that she missed 88 percent of Senate estimates hearings over the past decade.

If politicians had to live like the rest of us, maybe they'd think differently about the decisions they make in parliament. That's why all Victorian Socialists candidates are bound to take only an average full-time worker's wage—equivalent to the salary of a sixth-year nurse, currently around \$96,000—and put the rest back into progressive campaigns and community initiatives in their local area. And, if elected, they will fight to cut back all politicians' salaries and entitlements in the same way.

Key facts

The rich get richer...

The 200 wealthiest Australians now control \$707 billion, up \$40 billion from last year, and a giant leap from the collective \$197.3 billion held by the country's richest just ten years ago.

A massive 93 percent of the wealth increases from economic growth flowed to the richest 10 percent of income earners between 2009 and 2019, according to the Australia Institute, a think tank. By comparison, in the 1950s, 96 percent of the benefits flowed to the bottom 90 percent.

Shaded areas indicate Labor (red) and Coalition (blue) federal governments

— Top 10% of income earners' pre-tax national income share
— Bottom 50% of income earners' share

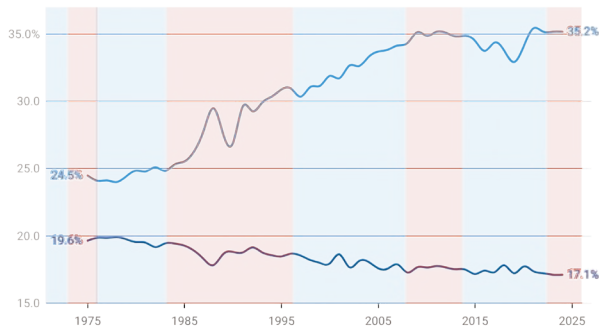


Chart: Ben Hillier, Red Flag • Source: World Inequality Database • Created with Datawrapper

— Top 1% of income earners' pre-tax national income share

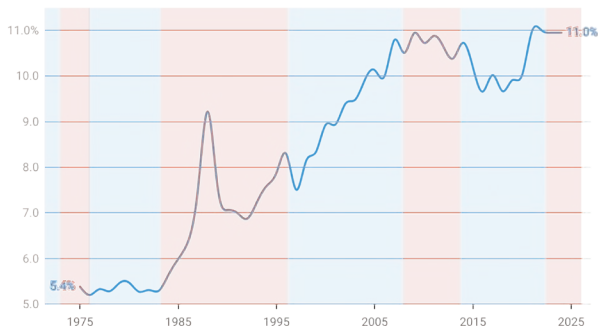


Chart: Ben Hillier, Red Flag • Source: World Inequality Database • Created with Datawrapper

Wealth of Australia's richest people as a share of GDP

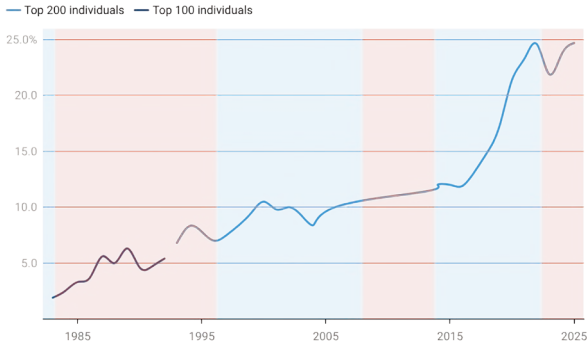


Chart: Ben Hillier, Red Flag • Source: BRW/AFR Rich List; ABS; The Australia Institute; Eaton and Stilwell "The super rich in Australia"; Stilwell and Ansari "Wealthy Australians" • Created with Datawrapper

...workers and the poor get left behind

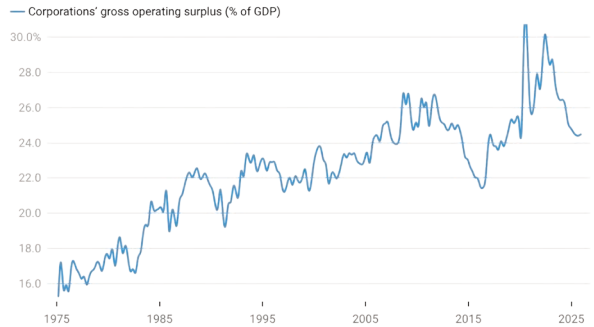


Chart: Ben Hillier, Red Flag • Source: ABS • Created with Datawrapper

Real wages today are only marginally higher than they were thirteen years ago. And they are going backwards again now that inflation has increased due to Donald Trump's war on Iran.

More than 10 percent of Australian households are in housing stress (spending more than 30 percent of income on housing), according to the Australian Human Rights Commission. Among low-income households, housing stress is more than 50 percent.

More than 20 percent of renters are in severe rental stress (paying more than 50 percent of income on rent). And the average renter is now spending about one-third of their pre-tax income on rent—a record high.

Homelessness continues to rise: 102,000 people in 2011, 116,000 in 2016, and 122,494 in 2021, according to the Census. Specialist homelessness services say they are helping more people every year.

“For my entire life, I’ve seen how the wealth of the richest few has grown at working-class people’s expense. No matter who has been in government, it’s been the same. For more than a decade, I’ve been organising and fighting to turn this around. Running in this election is part of that fight.”

Anneke Demanuele
Victorian Socialists candidate
for Western Metro



How the Labor Party has failed workers

The Labor Party claims to stand for workers. Yet for many workers, life is harder today than it was when the party came to office in 1999—beginning a 23-year period of Labor rule, interrupted by a Liberal government in 2010-14. Life shouldn't be a struggle just to get by. But under Labor, that's exactly what it has become for increasing numbers of working-class people.

Wages aren't keeping up with inflation. We have to work more to pay the rent, never mind saving enough to buy a home. And many homeowners are suffering from mortgage stress—buried under a mountain of debt and higher interest rates as the banks post record profits.

Grocery bills are crippling. The cost of essentials like electricity, health care and education are rising day by day. Residents in growth areas endure ever longer commutes from suburbs that lack basic services and amenities—spending hours navigating threadbare public transport or paying exorbitant tolls to the private road operators that long ago covered the costs of construction. Regional Victorians continue to be deprived of equal access to the kind of resources and services that those in wealthy areas of inner Melbourne take for granted. No wonder so many people are angry!

Unlike the Liberals, Labor at least has to make a show of doing something to address the problems facing working-class people. But a show is all it ever amounts to. On the economic fundamentals, Labor and the Liberals agree: capitalists' profits come first.

Instead of building more public housing, Labor is demolishing it. The Victorian population has grown from 4.5 million 30 years ago to more than 7 million today. Yet the number of public housing units has been stuck at only 65,000—and much of it has fallen into a state of utter disrepair.

Labor could easily have renovated our public housing—and built more! Instead, they first neglected it, then said they had no choice but to tear it down and replace it with private developments with tiny numbers of so-called “affordable” housing units and social housing. And all this while rates of homelessness and public housing waiting lists have grown year by year.

Instead of properly investing in public infrastructure and services that working-class people depend on, Labor has poured massive sums into police and prisons. Between 2015 and 2025, annual government spending on police operations increased from around \$2.5 billion to more than \$4.5 billion—a real increase per person of 21 percent.

Meanwhile, the number of hospital beds per 1,000 people has declined. For those aged over 65—the time of life when it matters most—it’s down by 12 percent. Any paramedic, nurse or doctor working in the public healthcare system could tell you: statistics like these are just the tip of the iceberg. The entire health system is in permanent crisis—held together only by the commitment and sacrifice of the health professionals who make it run.

Victoria pitches itself as the “education state”. Yet our public schools are chronically underfunded—with facilities crumbling, class sizes ballooning and teachers at breaking point dealing with

The privatisation of electricity in Victoria

When electricity was generated and distributed by the State Electricity Commission of Victoria (SECV) it was much cheaper. The Bureau of Industry Economics in 1994 said that industry customers enjoyed the eighth-cheapest prices compared to 40 comparable countries. It also

made money for the government—which it could spend on other services. In the year before Kennett began its privatisation, the SECV paid a \$191 million dividend to the state Treasury and made a profit of \$207 million.

ever increasing workloads. Teachers are working more than twelve hours of unpaid overtime a week, and many support staff are forced to take second jobs to get by.

Meanwhile, private schools continue to get billions in funding from the state and federal governments. Where does that money go? Rooftop tennis courts, Olympic swimming pools, theatre complexes, equestrian centres and other things. Taken together, the under-investment in public schools and the over-investment in private schools is deepening educational inequality and entrenching disadvantage across generations. It's the opposite of what a government that claims to stand for working-class people should be doing.

Labor has also continued the privatisation agenda and public-private partnership model that, since the Jeff Kennett Liberal era in the 1990s, has resulted in much of our state's essential resources and public services being sold to the highest bidder. The result has been poorer quality services and higher prices.

It's the same wherever you look. From child care and aged care to vocational education, to "public" transport and roads—whatever the privatisation agenda has touched, it has made worse and/or more expensive. The only people who benefit are the capitalists who buy up our assets and services on the cheap. For them, every dollar saved by cutting costs on staffing and running down the services, and every dollar won by increasing prices, is another dollar in the bank.

The rorts associated with Big Build projects are another example. It's clear that Victorians have been ripped off to the tune of billions

But after it was privatised by Kennett in the early 1990s, the situation grew worse year by year. According to a 2019 Australia Institute report by economist David Richardson, real output per employee in the industry fell by 38 percent between 2000 and 2018 as the number of sales representatives rose by almost 400 percent and the number of managers increased 217 percent. That's the free market's superior efficiency capitalists are always telling us about.

Unsurprisingly, the result was rapid price rises. An earlier report by Richardson found that Australian electricity prices increased by 170 percent on average between 1995 and 2012—"four times higher than the rise in the consumer price index". Richardson estimated that every customer pays a \$100 to \$200 yearly premium "for the privilege of being hounded with advertising and marketing for a basic service".

by private developers who view government-backed projects as a licence to print money. A publicly owned developer and builder could help address these issues. But this isn't something today's "big business first" Labor Party would ever consider.

The party has put profits before people and the environment by approving new offshore gas exploration in the Otway Basin—locking in new emissions for decades to come—and continuing native logging by stealth. Now the Allan government wants to make Melbourne Australia's data-centre capital, prioritising big tech profits over working-class communities while driving unsustainable growth in water and electricity consumption.

Like its federal counterpart, the state Labor government is a loyal servant of imperialist interests. Throughout the Gaza genocide and the associated wars on Lebanon and Iran, it has been a steadfast supporter of Israel and its US sponsor. Instead of taking a stand against the barbarity being inflicted on the Palestinian people, it has attacked the Palestine solidarity movement and increased restrictions on freedom of speech and the right to protest. More, Premier Jacinta Allan personally greeted Israeli President Isaac Herzog—a man investigated by the UN and other international bodies over credible accusations of incitement to genocide.

Labor has also shown itself all too willing to facilitate the growing integration of Australia into the US-led military alliance as it

How Labor has betrayed its working-class base

Firefighters, nurses, teachers and ambulance workers played a crucial role in Labor's 2014 and 2018 election wins, knocking on thousands of doors and staffing polling booths to help win votes in marginal seats. In his 2018 victory speech, Premier Daniel Andrews thanked "all the members of the trade union movement" for contributing to his re-election. Yet most public sector workers' real

wages have gone backwards—by 10 percent or more over the past few years.

Significant sections of the healthcare workforce (including allied health workers such as physios, medical scientists and now even doctors) are taking industrial action against a Labor government that refuses to lift their living standards or fix the workload crises in public health.

prepares for a possible future conflict with China. It has given the green light for the US to construct a \$42 million military storage facility just outside Wodonga. And it has been an enthusiastic supporter of the AUKUS deal, under which hundreds of billions of our tax dollars are set to be poured away so Australia can (maybe one day) get a small fleet of nuclear-powered submarines.

Even Labor's much celebrated treaty with Aboriginal people, signed on 13 November last year, was overshadowed by the announcement (the day before) of new "adult time for violent crime" laws that could result in children jailed for life, and which will disproportionately affect Indigenous kids.

Labor will do anything to deflect blame for the issues facing working-class Victorians. But there's no escaping reality. After twelve years of uninterrupted state Labor rule, and four years of combined federal and state Labor rule, Victoria has never been as much as a paradise for billionaires, big business and the super-rich. But for workers and the poor, life is as hard, or harder, than ever.

It's clear that the threat posed by One Nation doesn't mean we should rally behind the status quo as a "lesser evil". Doing that will only further fuel the rise of the far right. We need a party that puts the interests of working-class people first. A party that will stand up to the billionaires and big corporate interests, and fight to win the more equal and sustainable society we need and deserve.

The same goes for teachers and other school staff, who in June voted to reject a new statewide agreement recommended by the Labor government and their own union leaders—an agreement that did nothing to address the growing crisis of funding, workload and burnout among public school staff.

Most fire trucks—65 percent—are past their service life, and firefighters can't get the government to act. Ambos won a pay rise that matches inflation only after a prolonged industrial dispute. Nurses got the same after rejecting a crap deal and threatening more strikes in

2024. Local council workers are in a prolonged dispute for the funding, wages and conditions that Labor is refusing to provide. Repeated rounds of job cuts are decimating crucial public sector services and workforces—from library services to VicHealth to Parks Victoria and across many other agencies.

Labor has held power for twelve years largely thanks to the support of public sector workers. It made big promises, but delivered a real pay cut to many workers and a crisis in funding, services and workloads.

“Labor, the Coalition and One Nation all share the same agenda of cuts and privatisation that has laid waste to working-class communities across our state. Only socialist politics offers a vision of solidarity and collective struggle that can push back the right and start to win the change we need.”

Omar Hassan

Victorian Socialists candidate
for Northern Metro

Victorian
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The Liberals and One Nation will only make things worse

Neither the Coalition nor One Nation offer solutions for workers' problems. The Liberals are the A-team of capitalism—serving big business is in their DNA. A Liberal-led government would bring more of the same kind of politics we've seen under Labor, only without even the pretence of governing in the interests of workers. More privatisation. Savage job cuts. Lower wages. Greater inequality. Most likely all dished up with a sprinkling of "Hanson-lite" politics of division. That's all we can expect from the Liberals.

One Nation is essentially no different—just more bigoted and more hostile to the workers' movement. Hanson poses as an outsider but, just like her hero Donald Trump, she has always been a servant of the elite. That's why Australia's richest billionaire, Gina Rinehart—who once complained about Australian workers not being prepared to work for \$2 a day—is such an enthusiastic backer of One Nation. And that's why, in Victoria, some of the biggest donors to One Nation's campaign are property developers angry at having to pay additional taxes on land they're withholding from the market, and business owners who want more restrictions on workers' rights.

One Nation is useful to billionaires and other wealthy elites because its brand of divide-and-rule scapegoating distracts from the people who profit the most from things like the housing crisis and the rising cost of living: the big banks, the major supermarkets, the capitalists who bought up all our public assets on the cheap. If One Nation's brand of politics becomes entrenched in Victoria, it will be yet another setback for working-class people, and yet another boon for business owners and billionaires.



Our vision for a better, fairer Victoria

A vote for Victorian Socialists is a vote for something radically different to the major parties. Our vision is summed up by our slogan: “People before profit”. We want to pull the emergency brake on capitalism’s out of control drive to private profit and instead move towards a socialist economy and society in which working-class people, our communities and the environment we all depend on for survival come first.

At the centre of our election campaign is the push for a system of lifelong support, a Universal Living Guarantee to ensure that everyone, no matter their circumstances, has the things they need to live a good life. In one of the wealthiest countries on Earth, blessed with an abundance of land, resources and technology, and with a highly educated and skilled workforce, no-one should have to struggle to keep a roof over their head and food on the table. No-one should be denied a quality education, health care, aged care or other public services.

The main reason people are struggling today is that more and more of the wealth produced by workers is being hoarded by the class of capitalists and their hangers-on. And much of what does flow to the government in the form of taxes is spent on things like subsidies for fossil fuel companies and funding for elite private schools, the military, police and prisons and so on.

The right-wing media complains about the “socialist” policies of Labor in Victoria. That’s a joke. Big businesses are getting richer and workers are getting poorer—that’s Labor’s capitalist policies at work. Socialists have totally different priorities. We would increase taxes on the billionaires, big corporations, property investors and other elites. We would cut back all the tax breaks, subsidies and other forms of government support currently flowing to the wealthiest sections of society. And we would devote all our efforts to improving the lives of workers, the poor and oppressed. That’s what socialism is really about: for the many, not the few.

Our policies

In what follows we outline some of the key policies we're taking to this election. They form part of a broader and more detailed platform developed in recent months with input from Victorian Socialists members.



**Read the full
platform:**

victoriansocialists.org.au/policies



Homes for all

A 25 percent rent cut for all residential tenancies followed by a rent freeze for five years

Landlords have increased rents and squeezed everything they can out of tenants who have no other housing options. Australian rents increased by 44 percent on average in the five years to September 2025. During the same period, average wages grew by just 18 percent. To bring relief to renters, we would mandate a 25 percent rent cut in all residential tenancies—bringing rents back into line with wage growth—and freeze rents at that level for the next five years.

Universal Living Guarantee

Nobody should have to choose between eating or paying the bills. In Victoria, thousands of parents skip meals so they can feed their kids and keep the lights on. Victorian Socialists will fight for a Universal Living Guarantee—a set of economic and social supports at all stages of life to ensure everyone in the state can live comfortably.

The following are some of the key planks of the guarantee:

Free, publicly owned and operated child care, five days a week

150,000 new public housing units over ten years

A 25 percent rent cut for all residential tenancies, followed by a rent freeze for five years

Free public transport with increased services and availability across Melbourne and regional Victoria

\$100 price-cap trolleys at supermarkets and local cost-price food hubs in every community

Expanded and publicly run aged care with increased places and in-home services





A publicly owned and run construction firm to build energy-efficient public housing—150,000 units in ten years

A massive expansion of public housing is at the centre of our plan to transform the housing system from a profit-driven one to a needs-based one. We would set up a publicly owned and run construction firm to build 150,000 sustainable public homes over the next ten years. Adding more housing supply for people who need it most would also act as a lever to bring down rents and reduce the cost of homes for everyone.

A state bank offering low interest rates to working-class households

A State Bank of Victoria will offer to take over existing owner-occupier mortgages at below-market rates and provide below-market home loans while refusing to lend to residential property investors. Any profits would be invested in socially useful and necessary projects such as public housing and sustainability infrastructure.

Statewide audit and redistribution of empty and under-used property

Audit existing properties to identify those that are empty or underutilised. We'll bring into public ownership and redistribute homes that are fit for habitation but have been left empty and fix those that need fixing. We'll also ban property hoarding (more than five properties owned by one person) and bring properties vacant for more than two years without a legitimate reason into public ownership without compensation.



**A LIVING
WAGE FOR
EDUCATORS
NOW!**

**Making
everyday life
easier and
better**



Free, publicly owned and operated child care, five days a week

Childcare centres should not be run by private capitalists who view babies and preschoolers as a way to make a profit. The safety of children should be the highest priority. Their needs will be put first only in a system run to support families and to educate children. Socialists would establish a public childcare and early education system for children from six months until primary school, with enough places for everyone.

Free school lunches for all government primary school students

Free, nutritious school lunches to every Victorian government primary school student. As well as providing much needed relief to working-class families, this measure would create thousands of new, stable and well-paid catering jobs. We would also end all “voluntary” parent contributions for things like uniforms, devices, camps and excursions, which should be paid for out of the state’s general revenues to ensure that no child is left disadvantaged and no family is humiliated for lack of money.

\$100 price-cap trolleys at the supermarket and cost-price food hubs in every community

Supermarket profits continue to surge as working-class people struggle to put food on the table. We will introduce a \$100 price-cap trolley scheme where households can fill up with a range of staples for meals and other necessities for their weekly household needs. We’ll also establish distribution hubs in local communities across the state to supply grocery essentials at cost price.



Free public transport with increased services and availability

We saw earlier this year how easy it was for the government to make public transport free. This should be permanent—it reduces road congestion and reduces the cost of getting around. Transport infrastructure should be a public good, not a source of private profit. That means free, frequent, publicly owned public transport, safe and connected pedestrian and cycling infrastructure, and roads free of private tolls.



Free-to-air sports coverage including all AFL games

Sports shouldn't be a luxury reserved for people who can afford expensive subscriptions to streaming services like Kayo. We'll fight for a federal government mandate to guarantee the ABC and SBS have default free-to-air broadcasting rights to every AFL, NRL or other sports games or events held in Australia that are not otherwise covered by a free-to-air channel. We'll also bring back free three-quarter time entry to all AFL games played in Victoria.

Moving to a four-day work week

Gains in productivity always go to profits, not to workers. Further increases are expected to result from the increased use of artificial intelligence. We'll push to move toward a four-day week with an equivalent reduced workload at full pay, starting in the public sector and expanding from there.



Investing in better services

Increase funding for government schools and health services

Hire 12,000 additional teachers and support staff across Victoria's 1,600 public schools, boost salaries and cut class sizes to a maximum of 15 (smaller in specialist schools). We'll also increase public hospital beds to at least three per 1,000 Victorians alongside an immediate 2.5 percent-above-inflation pay rise for nurses, paramedics and allied health workers, with another rise in 2028.

Expand publicly run aged care with increased places and in-home services

Aged care, like child care, should not be run for profit. We'll expand public and community-based facilities, mandate registered nurses on-site 24/7, and fully fund public home care services including nursing and domestic assistance for seniors who want to stay in their own homes.



Expanded disability services including specialist provision and services for young people

We'll progressively bring private disability services into public hands, restore funding cuts and build a disability-community-designed alternative to the NDIS in Victoria.

Putting energy production back in public hands

The price of power in Victoria has risen at three times the rate of inflation since privatisation 30 years ago. We'll cap household electricity and gas bills at an affordable level (funded by taxes on energy companies), wipe existing household utility debts and take the energy grid back into public ownership. A new publicly owned energy operator will drive the transition to a 100 percent renewable grid, including offshore wind, battery storage and free rooftop solar and efficiency upgrades for public housing, schools and low-income households.



Improving liveability and sustainability

Planning for liveable cities

Melbourne's outer suburbs and regional Victoria get a fraction of the health care, education and transport access that the city's wealthier suburbs enjoy. We'll invest what's needed to ensure residents of these areas are no longer left behind. We'll also end public-private partnerships and land sell-offs, mandate at least 30 percent low-cost and public housing in all new residential developments, require 30 percent canopy tree coverage and give councils additional powers to put social equity ahead of developer profit in planning decisions.

Urgent action on climate change

Victoria's emissions are still rising while the state government opens new offshore gas exploration. We'll cut emissions 75 percent below 2005 levels by 2030, hit a zero-carbon economy by 2035 and be net negative by 2040. We'll bring forward the closure of Loy Yang A to 2030 with guaranteed support for affected workers, ban new fossil fuel projects effective immediately and commit to 100 percent electric new car sales by 2035.



STAND **AGAINST** RACISM

Fighting oppression and building solidarity

Support First Nations self-determination and sovereignty

The crimes of invasion and occupation, many of which are ongoing, perpetrated against First Nations people must be addressed. We'll establish a reparations tax on commercial and investment properties to help fund land theft reparations, work to limit the removal of First Nations' children into out-of-home care and implement all recommendations of the Royal Commission into Aboriginal Deaths in Custody, the Bringing Them Home Report and the Yoorrook Justice Commission.



Standing against homophobia and transphobia

“Culture war” attacks on LGBTI+ people have increased as Trump-style right-wing politics has spread internationally. We’ll remove the religious exemptions in Victorian law that allow discrimination, strengthen Victoria’s conversion practices ban and fully fund free and timely gender-affirming care, including for young people. We will oppose any attempt from One Nation or anyone else to codify bigotry in law.

Oppose racism and the criminal injustice system

Racist scapegoating of migrants is used to distract from the real causes of the cost-of-living crisis. We’ll raise the age of criminal responsibility to 16 and increase funding to the Victorian Aboriginal Legal Service, Melbourne Activist Legal Support, the Human Rights Law Centre and other community legal services that cater to marginalised, oppressed or economically disadvantaged communities. We’ll also declare Victoria a sanctuary state for those at risk of being deported to danger, fund legal support for migrant workers and refugees, and boost funding for multicultural community organisations, particularly in the outer suburbs.

Fight for women’s liberation

Women earn on average 79 cents for every dollar men earn and do a disproportionate amount of unpaid care work in society. We’ll expand paid parental leave to twelve months for the primary carer and six months for a secondary carer, close the gender pay gap in majority-women industries like teaching, nursing and aged care, make abortion freely available in all public hospitals and significantly boost funding for family violence and crisis support services.



**PEOPLE
BEFORE
PROFIT**
Victorian
Socialism

How would we pay for it?

Creating an economy and society that work for everyone will cost a lot. Fortunately, as we're reminded every year in the latest *Australian Financial Review* Rich List, there's no shortage of wealth in our society. Were it not being hoarded by the wealthy few, wasted on handouts to big businesses and drained through the massive salaries of politicians and high-level bureaucrats, all that wealth could be used to benefit everyone.

We'll implement a range of new measures targeting billionaires, big corporations and the super-rich to raise the funds we need to realise our vision:

- Applying a luxury properties tax on the top 1 percent of most valuable residences in Victoria, charged at 5 percent of their last sale price per year

- Applying a 10 percent wealth tax on billionaires and 10 percent tax on assets owned by foreign billionaires in Australia

- Doubling the payroll tax for large companies and trusts

- Increasing and properly enforcing taxes for land banking

- Imposing a levy on private jets landing at Essendon airport—\$5,000 landing fee for planes valued at more than \$500,000.

In addition, many of the policies in our platform would, if implemented, add new revenue streams to make those policies largely self-funding. This includes, most notably, the expansion of public housing, the re-nationalisation of energy production and distribution and the establishment of a state bank.



Our candidates

Victorian Socialists candidates aren't professional politicians. They're working-class people with a track record of organising and fighting for real change both locally, in their workplaces and communities, and globally, through their participation in the Palestine solidarity campaign, the fight for climate justice, anti-racist and anti-fascist movements and more. They don't want to get into parliament to make friends with the elites. They want to get in there to fight like hell against the major party politicians and the billionaire and corporate interests they serve.





services
FOR
Palestine

VICTORIAN
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STRIKE
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WEDNESDAY 10 SEPTEMBER
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Building a movement for real change (in this election and beyond)

Amid the darkness of the global far-right surge, there are glimmers of hope. In many countries, socialists are gaining ground. Millions of people in recent years have voted for parties like the Victorian Socialists—parties that want to break from the status quo of capitalism. And many of those people are joining those socialist parties and committing themselves to our movement.

More and more people are recognising that the big social problems aren't accidents, and that they're not going to be fixed with a bit of tinkering. Whether it's growing inequality, social dislocation, loneliness and mental ill-health, the destruction of the environment or the genocide in Gaza and the growing threat of global war—the multiplying crises of our society are crises of capitalism.



No other Australian political party is prepared to point out this reality. Labor, the Liberals and One Nation are unabashed servants of the capitalist class. But even the Greens, who have at times adopted some radical-sounding rhetoric, have never gone beyond arguing for this or that progressive change *within* the existing system.

Victorian Socialists is the only anti-capitalist party running in this election. Our entire approach to politics is informed by that. Running in elections on a left-wing policy program is just one part of the broader project of building a mass socialist movement with the power to overcome the entire rotten system and replace it with a socialist society.

Elections are of course important. But the idiotic circus that passes for political debate in parliament means that most people think that there's little point following it closely. That every few years we're expected to play our part in the democratic process by voting, however, provides a small opening. People stop to think about what sort of society they'd like to live in and which parties best reflect their values, their wants and their needs. It's at this moment that a socialist message of hope, solidarity and collective struggle for a better world can get a hearing that we are regularly denied in the corporate media.

Even if we don't succeed in getting any socialists elected to parliament, the exercise is worthwhile. The more people we can inspire with and win to a socialist vision of society, the more we can increase the number of *organised socialists* in our party, the better placed we'll be to continue to fight and build the power of our movement in the years ahead.



How does this election fit within the struggle for a socialist society? Parliament is just one of many institutions that help the capitalists dominate our economy and society. To break with the capitalist system, we need to take back control from the capitalist class not only via the “official channels” of parliamentary democracy, but also through organising real democracy in workplaces, local communities and on the streets.

The US socialist historian Howard Zinn wrote: “What matters most is not who is sitting in the White House, but ‘who is sitting in’—and who is marching outside the White House, pushing for change”. Australian history shows this to be true, too. It’s no accident that the most progressive period of politics in Australia, the early 1970s, coincided with a high-point of working-class organisation and union militancy (for example, the Builders Labourers’ Federation’s Green Bans) and of mass social movements like the campaign against the war in Vietnam.

The capitalist class own and control the most important sections of our economy—the banks, the supermarkets, the telecommunications and transport infrastructure, the factories and mines and office towers, most of the farmland and so on. They own the media and they buy the politicians. As long as their power is left undisturbed, we will never win the kind of change we need.

A socialist MP would, from day one, face a barrage of criticism from the major parties and the corporate media. Their work would be hampered, at every turn, by the state bureaucracy. Our solution to this isn’t merely to elect socialist parliamentarians who will fight the establishment no matter what. It’s to have those parliamentarians do everything they can to build the socialist movement outside the parliament to back up their efforts within it.

A people-powered campaign

The challenge for the Victorian Socialists is to make our voice heard above the clamour of propaganda from more established parties and the right-wing media. Unlike the major parties, we can't spend millions on paid advertising to get our message out. We depend on people power—on the time and energy of our members and supporters.

We need an army of people to deliver letters, knock on doors and have discussions with tens of thousands of voters, put up yard signs, staff community outreach stalls and phone banks, and hand out how to vote cards at polling booths. We'll win people to vote for us, and to embrace the socialist vision of society we're putting forward, only if they know we exist!

That's why the Victorian Socialists don't focus just on elections. We're also active—year in, year out—rebuilding cultures of resistance in our trade unions, helping to organise progressive campaigns like the Palestine solidarity movement, organising our local communities to take on greedy developers and polluters and much more. An example is the work that socialist public school teachers and support staff—organised in the VS-backed Socialists in Schools rank-and-file union group—have been doing to fight for a fair contract from the Labor government.

Winning the change we need requires much more of this kind of action and activism, particularly within the workers' movement. So a big part of the job of a socialist MP would be to encourage and help organise it. They would use their public profile and the resources that come with their office to provide support to striking workers and others fighting for progressive change. Not only because it's the right thing to do, but because building more powerful movements for change outside parliament is the only way change can be won inside parliament.

This kind of work is also necessary because it's the key to building a socialist society: a society run by and for working-class people. Truly revolutionary change cannot be handed down from on high. It must be built from below. Every strike, every protest, every small act of resistance is like a school in which people learn to lead, learn to organise, learn to fight collectively—and learn how to win.



In areas where we do all these things, we always find people who will not only vote for us but who will join our movement. Many people are politically inactive not because they like and accept the way things are. They just lack the confidence to get involved or think that real change is impossible.

Every letter we deliver, every conversation we have and every vote we win, challenges that sentiment. On election day, if we achieve the kind of breakthrough result we believe is possible, we will shake up the entire political setup in Victoria by showing that when you fight, you can win.



A group of approximately 15-20 people are sitting in a circle on a wooden floor in a room. In the background, there is a refrigerator, a poster that says "REDE FLAG", and a white door. The people are dressed in casual clothing, and some are holding papers or notebooks. The room appears to be a community space or a meeting room.

Victorian
Socialists

**Become a
member**

victoriansocialists.org.au/join



Join us and get involved

If you agree with the vision outlined in this manifesto and you're not yet a Victorian Socialists member, join us and get involved. A regular membership is \$84 annually (that's just \$1.60 a week). Once you've joined and your membership application has been approved, a local coordinator in your area will get in touch.

As a member, you can participate in party discussions, preselections and other internal elections from the local level to statewide and national levels. You can help shape the party's policies, campaigns and future directions.

There are local branches in many areas of Melbourne and regional Victoria, many of which have regular monthly in-person branch meetings. At these meetings, members discuss current issues in Australian and international politics and the campaigns we're involved in. We also discuss the organising and planning of branch activities. In areas where we're only just becoming established, members are connected through WhatsApp chats and other channels.

Between now and November, much of this local work will be devoted to campaigning for the state election. We'll be doing a lot of letterboxing, door knocking, phone banking and delivering yard signs. We'll be organising campaign meetings and volunteer training sessions. And once polling opens—during the week and a half of pre-polling and on election day, Saturday, 28 November—we will be handing out how-to-vote cards and talking to voters at polling stations across the state.

No matter what your background, experience or level of confidence, everyone is welcome. There's a wide range of activities in which you can make a valuable contribution to our campaign. Unlike the major parties, which get big donations from corporations and other wealthy backers, we depend on our members and supporters to get the message out. And the bigger the base of active members we can build, the stronger we'll become!

This manifesto was written and produced on the land of the Wurundjeri people of the Kulin Nation. We acknowledge the Elders, families and forebears—the traditional owners and custodians. Their land was stolen, never ceded, and we stand in solidarity with their ongoing struggle against racism and capitalism.



**Capitalism is
killing our future.
For real change,
vote socialist.**



**Victorian
Socialists**

Authorised by C. Oakley, 83 Sydney Rd, Brunswick VIC 3056